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Too much driving is bad for society, new studies show

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By Chris McCahill

Making it easier to drive less is a key strategy for cutting carbon emissions and easing highway congestion. Some states—[California](https://www.sb743.org/) (<https://www.sb743.org/>), [Connecticut](https://portal.ct.gov/dot/pp_bureau/2030-vmt-goals-and-strategies?language=en_US) (https://portal.ct.gov/dot/pp_bureau/2030-vmt-goals-and-strategies?language=en_US), [Colorado](https://environmentamerica.org/articles/colorados-rule-that-promotes-driving-less-and-living-more-explained/) (<https://environmentamerica.org/articles/colorados-rule-that-promotes-driving-less-and-living-more-explained/>), [Minnesota](https://www.srfconsulting.com/vmt-legislation-provides-opportunity/) (<https://www.srfconsulting.com/vmt-legislation-provides-opportunity/>), and [Washington](https://wsdot.wa.gov/sites/default/files/2023-06/VMT-Targets-Final-Report-June2023.pdf) (<https://wsdot.wa.gov/sites/default/files/2023-06/VMT-Targets-Final-Report-June2023.pdf>), for example—have noted this in their climate policies. New research, however, shows that driving less doesn't just benefit the environment. It can also boost personal well-being and strengthen social connections.

It turns out trying to expand the freedom of the open road has its limits—when taken too far, it can end up driving people apart.

[Researchers](https://doi.org/10.1016/j.tbs.2024.100954) (<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.tbs.2024.100954>) from Arizona State surveyed more than 2,000 adults across the U.S. to understand how car dependence affects personal satisfaction in life. In moderation, they found, car use increases personal wellbeing by giving people better access and sense of freedom. “It’s not surprising that car use would increase life satisfaction,” they explain, “especially in the U.S. where the built environment and transportation infrastructure are developed around car usage.”

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However, the benefits are only good up to a certain point, then car use has the opposite effect:

“In a typical week, relying on a car for more than 50% of the time for out-of-home activities is associated with a decrease in life satisfaction. This implies that at high levels of car dependence, there are negative implications that outweigh the benefits of car-based travel.”

In addition, a new [German study \(https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jenvp.2023.102125\)](https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jenvp.2023.102125) suggests that getting out of the car and onto a bike makes people more oriented toward the “common good.” The authors explain:

“On an individual level, cycling can contribute to the direct experience of the neighborhood environment, which might motivate people to be helpful, to get engaged in social organizational participation and in political participation. [...] The multitude of mostly casual public contacts would give rise to helpfulness and a social identity of people, associated with respect and trust. People who travel by bike experience the local infrastructure more directly, recognize social grievances and see people in need of help earlier. Cycling in big cities not only offers a high potential to experience the social environment, but also enables spontaneous interaction with other mobile people, such as cyclists, pedestrians or lingering people.”

This is not the first study to make the claim. The authors point to [similar research \(https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ypmed.2021.106666\)](https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ypmed.2021.106666) in Wisconsin from 2021 that found the more often people walk or bike, the more likely they are to engage in community issues by writing letters, making phone calls, and attending public meetings. According to the study, living in walkable areas also leads to a stronger sense of community and sociopolitical control.

All three studies recommend land use policies and transportation investments that promote walking and biking while expanding travel options beyond driving.

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